

ANCIENT HISTORY — PART 5

JAINISM & BUDDHISM — HETERODOX MOVEMENTS OF THE 6TH CENTURY BC

Causes of Origin

Mahavira & Jainism

Buddha & Buddhism

Councils

Texts & Sects

Architecture

Part 5 / 7 — Ancient History Series — SSC CGL / CHSL / CPO / MTS-GD

CGL READY PROMISE

Full lecture + notes content on Jainism and Buddhism, with every PYQ-verified gap fact (founder traps, family relations, council presidents, text authorship) woven directly into its relevant topic below — no separate "extra facts" section.

1. Causes of Origin (Heterodox Movements)

Cause	Detail
Brahminical domination	Excessive emphasis on rituals/sacrifices, controlled by Brahmins, alienated other varnas
Impact on trade	Ritualistic sacrifices (killing cattle for yajnas) disrupted the agricultural/trade economy that depended on cattle
Rise of coinage	Use of punch-marked coins boosted trade, strengthening the Vaishya class, who resented Brahmin dominance
Rejection of Varna rigidity	Both religions did not attach importance to the existing birth-based Varna system — believed varna should be based on karma (occupation) , not birth
Ahimsa	Both religions placed strong emphasis on non-violence

Both Mahavira and Buddha belonged to the **Kshatriya** class — a notable point since they arose partly as a Kshatriya reaction to Brahmin dominance.

2. Jainism — Tirthankaras

Tirthankara	Detail
Total	24 Tirthankaras
1st — Rishabhadeva (Rishabhdev)	Birthplace: Ayodhya; symbol: Bull; mentioned in the Rig Veda — one of only two Tirthankaras named in the Vedas
22nd — Arishtanemi/Neminath	The other Tirthankara mentioned in the Vedas
23rd — Parshvanath	Birthplace: Varanasi; symbol: Serpent
24th — Vardhaman Mahavira	Main propagator/systematiser of Jainism; symbol: Lion

DIRECT PYQ TRAP

"Who was the founder of Jainism?" — Several SSC CHSL/CGL papers (e.g. SSC CHSL 4-7-2019 Shift-1, SSC CHSL 24-3-2018) give the correct answer as **Rishabhadeva** (the first Tirthankara), NOT Mahavira — since Jain tradition regards Rishabhadeva as the original founder, while Mahavira (24th Tirthankara) is the one who **revived, systematised and popularised** the religion into its historically attested form around 540 BC. If the option list includes Rishabhadeva, pick him for "founder"; if the question asks who "established the current form of Jainism" or similar systematising language, Mahavira is correct. Also: "Who was the first Tirthankara of the Jains?" → **Rishabhadeva** (SSC MTS 24-10-2017, SSC CGL 1999).

3. Vardhaman Mahavira — Life Details

Event	Detail
Birth	c. 540 BC, at Kundagrama, in Vaishali, Bihar
Death (Moksha)	468 BC (72 years old), at Pavapuri (Biharsharif), Bihar
Father	Siddhartha, of the Jnatrika (Kshatriya) clan
Mother	Trishala — described in the lecture simply as his mother; note the important PYQ correction below
Wife	Yashoda
Daughter	Anojja Priyadarshini, married to Jamali, who became Mahavira's first disciple
Son	Not mentioned in main lecture line — note: some sources give no biological son, distinguishing him from Buddha (who had son Rahul)
Renunciation age	30 years — left home along with Makkhali Gosala, who later broke away to found the Ajivika sect (extreme fatalism/asceticism)
Enlightenment (Kaivalya)	At age 42, after 12 years of asceticism, under a Sal tree at Jrimbhikagrama, on the banks of the river Rijupalika; attained status of Kevalin ("perfectly learned") / Jitendriya
First sermon	At Pava
Alternate name (Pali)	Nigantha Nataputta

literature)	
Jain monasteries	Called Basadis

DIRECT PYQ CORRECTION

A recurring UPSC/SSC-adjacent PYQ specifically corrects a common error: Mahavira's mother **Trishala was the SISTER (not daughter) of the Lichchhavi chief Chetak** — this makes Mahavira a nephew of the powerful Lichchhavi ruling house of Vaishali, an important family/political link. Also: "Vardhamana Mahavira was born at ___ and died at ___" → **Kundagrama and Pava** (i.e. death is commonly tested as "Pava," used interchangeably with Pavapuri).

4. Jain Philosophy — Path to Moksha

Term	Meaning
Triratna/Ratnatraya (Three Jewels of Jainism)	Samyak Darshan (Right Faith), Samyak Jnana (Right Knowledge), Samyak Charitra (Right Conduct) — remember as KFC (Knowledge-Faith-Conduct)
Syadvada	The fundamental epistemological basis of Jainism — doctrine of conditioned/relative predication ("maybe" logic); a direct PYQ links Syadvada specifically to Jainism
Anuvrata	The "five small vows" for Jain householders (lay followers) — a direct PYQ links this term specifically to Jainism
Five types of Jnana (knowledge)	Mati Jnana (sensory/mind knowledge), Shruta Jnana (scriptural knowledge), Avadhi Jnana (clairvoyance), Manahpariyaya Jnana (telepathy), Kevala Jnana (omniscience — the highest)

5. Panchvrata — Five Great Vows (Mahavratas)

Vow	Meaning
Ahimsa	Non-violence
Satya	Truthfulness
Asteya	Non-stealing
Aparigraha	Non-possession/non-attachment to material things
Brahmacharya	Celibacy/chastity

DIRECT PYQ TRAP

"Which is NOT among the five Mahavratas of Jainism?" (SSC CGL 12-9-2016 Shift-2) — Options include Satya, Brahmacharya, Aparigraha, and Dhyana. The correct answer (i.e. the one that is **NOT** a Mahavrata) is **Dhyana** (meditation) — Dhyana is a general spiritual practice, not one of the five core vows.

6. Jain Symbols by Tirthankara

Tirthankara	Symbol
1st (Rishabhadeva), 23rd (Parshvanath)	Bull; Serpent respectively
24th (Mahavira)	Lion

7. Divisions Among Jains

Event	Detail
Famine in Magadha	Caused a split — one group, led by Bhadrabahu , migrated south to Karnataka (Shravanabelagola) along with Chandragupta Maurya, who adopted Jainism and later died there by Sallekhana (ritual fasting unto death), c. 300 BC
Digambara sect	Founded/led by Bhadrabahu; "sky-clad" — did not wear clothing; associated with the group that went to South India
Shvetambara sect	Those who stayed in Magadha, led by Sthulabhadra , started wearing white clothes — hence "white-clad"
South Indian spread	Jainism spread to South India specifically under the leadership of Bhadrabahu — do not confuse this with Sthulabhadra, who stayed in the north

8. Jain Councils

Council	Detail
First Jain Council	298 BC (lecture) / 3rd century BC (general dating), at Pataliputra; presided over by Sthulabhadra ; resulted in the compilation of the 12 Angas (Jain scriptures); politically supported/patronised by Chandragupta Maurya and later Bindusara
Second Jain Council	512 AD (lecture) / 5th century AD (general dating), at Vallabhi, Gujarat; presided over by Devardhigani Kshamashramana ; resulted in the final written redaction/compilation of the Jain canon

Compare with Buddhism: Jainism had **2** councils; Buddhism had **4** councils.

9. Jain Literature & Texts

Text	Detail
Language	Prakrit
Agam Sutra	General term for canonical Jain scriptures
Bhagavati Sutra	Important Jain text; also cited as a source listing Mahajanapadas
Kalpa Sutra	Attributed to Bhadrabahu; contains biographies of the Tirthankaras
12 Angas	Compiled at the First Jain Council under Sthulabhadra

10. Jain Architecture

Site	Detail
Udayagiri & Khandagiri Caves	Odisha; rock-cut cave temples; associated with King Kharavela
Hathigumpha Caves	Odisha; associated with Kharavela
Dilwara Jain Temple	Mount Abu, Rajasthan; built by the Vastupala brothers
Statue of Gomateshwara/Bahubali	Shravanabelagola, Karnataka; Bahubali was the son of the 1st Tirthankara; site of the Mahamastyabhishek festival

Patrons of Jainism	Detail
Chandragupta Maurya & Bindusara	Royal patrons
Bimbisara & Ajatashatru	Both were contemporaries of Mahavira and Buddha

11. Buddhism — Gautam Buddha's Life

Event	Detail
Clan	Shakya clan
Birth	563 BC, Lumbini, Nepal — symbolised by the Lotus
Death (Mahaparinirvana)	483 BC, Kushinagara — symbolised by the Stupa
Childhood name	Siddhartha
Father	Suddhodhana
Mother	Mahamaya
Step-mother	Mahaprajapati Gautami — became the first Bhikkuni (female Buddhist monk)
Wife	Yashodhara
Son	Rahul
Great Departure (renunciation)	Left home at age 29 — symbolised by a Horse named Kanthaka; charioteer named Channa (names sometimes given in reverse in different sources)
First teacher	Alara Kalama
Second teacher	Udraka Ramaputra
Enlightenment (Nirvana)	At Uruvela (Bodh Gaya), under a Bodhi (Peepal) tree, on the banks of the river Niranjana, after 6 years of asceticism — symbolised by the Bodhi Tree
First sermon	Dhammachakra Pravartana ("turning the wheel of dharma") at Sarnath (Deer Park), Varanasi — symbolised by the Wheel

MINISTRY OF CULTURE MATCHING SET
Birth = Lumbini, Nepal (Lotus) • Enlightenment = Bodh Gaya, on the banks of Niranjana (Bodhi Tree) • First Sermon = Sarnath, Deer Park, Varanasi (Wheel) • Mahaparinirvana = Kushinagara (Stupa).

12. Buddhist Philosophy

Concept	Detail
Four Noble Truths	1. Life is full of suffering (Dukkha) 2. Desire is the root cause of suffering (Samudaya) 3. Suffering can be ended (Nirodha) 4. The Eightfold Path leads to the end of suffering (Magga)
Ashtangika Marga	Right View, Right Intention, Right Speech, Right Action, Right Livelihood, Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, Right Concentration

(Eightfold Path)	
Triratna (Three Jewels of Buddhism)	Buddha (the teacher), Dhamma (the teaching), Sangha (the monastic community/order) — do not confuse with Jainism's separate "Triratna"/Ratnatraya (Samyak Darshan-Jnana-Charitra); if a question just says "Triratna" without specifying the religion, both Buddhism and Jainism have a concept by this name, but Buddhism's Buddha-Dhamma-Sangha version is the one most commonly tested as the default "Triratna" answer
Nirvana	"The extinction of the flame of desire" — the commonly tested definition, over more mystical-sounding distractor options

13. Buddhist Texts

Text	Detail
Tripitaka (three baskets)	Main canonical Buddhist literature, mostly in Pali (some in Sanskrit)
Sutta Pitaka	Buddha's sermons/teachings
Vinaya Pitaka	Rules and regulations for monks (Sangha)
Abhidhamma Pitaka	Philosophical/doctrinal interpretation of the Sutta
Milindapanho	Pali text; dialogue between the Indo-Greek king Milinda (Menander) and the monk Nagasena — Milinda converts to Buddhism
Buddhacharita	Sanskrit text; biography of Buddha, by Ashvaghosha
Jataka Tales	Stories of Buddha's previous births, in both human and animal forms

14. Buddhist Councils

Council	Year/place	Patron	President
First	483/400 BC, Rajagriha	Ajatashatru	Mahakashyapa
Second	383 BC, Vaishali	Kalashoka	Sabakami
Third	250 BC, Pataliputra	Ashoka	Moggaliputta Tissa (also called Moghalpura Tissa in some notes)
Fourth	72 AD/78 AD, Kundalvan, Kashmir	Kanishka	Vasumitra

DIRECT PYQ

"Who patronised the Third Buddhist Council, held at Pataliputra?" → **Ashoka** (not Kanishka, Kalashoka or Ajatashatru — these are the patrons of the 4th, 2nd and 1st councils respectively; a classic matching-trap set). The Fourth Council resulted in the formal split into **Hinayana** and Mahayana sects.

15. Sects of Buddhism

Sect	Belief	Text
Hinayana	Did NOT believe in idol worship; saw Buddha in human/original form	Pali
Mahayana	Believed in idol worship; saw Buddha as a divine figure; introduced the concept of Bodhisattva (Avalokiteshwara, Padmapani, Amitabha)	Sanskrit
Vajrayana	Tantric Buddhism; prevalent in Eastern regions	—

Mahayana spread to Japan, China, Korea. Hinayana/Theravada spread to South and Southeast Asia — Sri Lanka, Indonesia, Cambodia, Malaysia.

16. Buddhist Architecture

Term	Meaning
Chaitya	Prayer hall / place of worship
Vihara	Residence for Buddhist monks
Stupa parts	Anda (hemispherical dome), Harmika, Chhatra (three umbrellas — symbolising the Triratna), Torana (gateway), Medhi/Pradakshina Path (circumambulation path)

Stupa	Location
Kesariya	Bihar — largest stupa in India
Dhamek	Sarnath, Uttar Pradesh
Rambhar	Kushinagar, Uttar Pradesh
Sanchi	Madhya Pradesh
Bharhut	Madhya Pradesh — depicts Jataka Tales
Borobudur	Java, Indonesia (outside India)

University	Founder
Nalanda	Kumaragupta I
Vikramshila	Dharmapala (Pala dynasty)
Odantapuri	Gopala (Pala dynasty)

8 Holy Places of Buddhism: Lumbini, Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Kushinagara, Rajgir, Vaishali, Shravasti, Sankasia.

17. Decline of Buddhism — Key Reason

DIRECT PYQ

"What was the main cause of the decline of Buddhism (per commonly tested passages)?" → **Lack of sincere and determined royal patronage** (over distractor options like "indiscriminate killing of cattle" or "complexity of Vedic religion," which relate to Buddhism's own rise, not its later decline).

18. Master Revision — Learn These First

Trigger	Answer
Founder of Jainism (as per several SSC PYQs)	Rishabhadeva (1st Tirthankara)
Systematiser of current Jainism	Vardhaman Mahavira (24th Tirthankara)
First Tirthankara	Rishabhadeva; symbol Bull
Two Tirthankaras named in the Vedas	1st (Rishabhadeva) and 22nd (Arishtanemi)
Mahavira's mother's relation to Chetak	Sister (Trishala) — not daughter
Mahavira born / died at	Kundagrama / Pava (Pavapuri)
Mahavira's Pali-literature name	Nigantha Nataputta
NOT among the 5 Mahavratas	Dhyana
Term linked to Jain epistemology	Syadvada
Term for Jain lay-follower vows	Anuvrata
Highest of 5 types of Jnana	Kevala Jnana (omniscience)
Digambara founder	Bhadrabahu
Shvetambara founder	Sthulabhadra
Jainism spread to South India under	Bhadrabahu
First Jain Council — president	Sthulabhadra (Pataliputra, 3rd c. BC); produced 12 Angas
Second Jain Council — president	Devardhigani Kshamashramana (Vallabhi, 5th c. AD)
Kalpa Sutra author	Bhadrabahu
Founder of Buddhism	Gautama Buddha (Siddhartha)
Buddha's clan	Shakya
Buddha born/died at	Lumbini / Kushinagara
First Bhikkuni	Mahaprajapati Gautami
Buddha's horse (Great Departure)	Kanthaka
Buddha's charioteer	Channa
Definition of Nirvana (standard PYQ)	"The extinction of the flame of desire"
Triratna of Buddhism	Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha
Third Buddhist Council patron	Ashoka (Pataliputra)
Fourth Buddhist Council	Kanishka, Kundalvan (Kashmir); split into Hinayana/Mahayana
Sect believing in idol worship	Mahayana
Concept unique to Mahayana	Bodhisattva
Main cause of Buddhism's decline	Lack of sustained royal patronage
Largest stupa in India	Kesariya, Bihar
Stupa depicting Jataka Tales	Bharhut, Madhya Pradesh

19. PYQ-Style Question Bank

Q1. Who is regarded as the founder of Jainism in several SSC PYQs? **Ans:** Rishabhadeva.

- Q2.** Who was the first Tirthankara? **Ans:** Rishabhadeva.
- Q3.** Which two Tirthankaras are mentioned in the Vedas? **Ans:** 1st (Rishabhadeva) and 22nd (Arishtanemi).
- Q4.** What relation was Trishala (Mahavira's mother) to the Lichchhavi chief Chetak? **Ans:** Sister.
- Q5.** Where was Mahavira born and where did he die? **Ans:** Kundagrama (birth); Pava/Pavapuri (death).
- Q6.** By what name is Mahavira known in Pali literature? **Ans:** Nigantha Nataputta.
- Q7.** Which is NOT among the five Mahavratas of Jainism? **Ans:** Dhyana.
- Q8.** Which term denotes the fundamental epistemological basis of Jainism? **Ans:** Syadvada.
- Q9.** Which term refers to the small vows for Jain lay-followers? **Ans:** Anuvrata.
- Q10.** What is the highest of the five types of Jain knowledge? **Ans:** Kevala Jnana.
- Q11.** Who founded the Digambara sect, and who founded the Shvetambara sect? **Ans:** Bhadrabahu; Sthulabhadra.
- Q12.** Under whose leadership did Jainism spread to South India? **Ans:** Bhadrabahu.
- Q13.** Who presided over the First Jain Council, and what was its output? **Ans:** Sthulabhadra; compilation of the 12 Angas.
- Q14.** Who presided over the Second Jain Council? **Ans:** Devardhigani Kshamashramana.
- Q15.** Who is the Kalpa Sutra attributed to? **Ans:** Bhadrabahu.
- Q16.** Who founded Buddhism? **Ans:** Gautama Buddha.
- Q17.** Which clan did Buddha belong to? **Ans:** Shakya.
- Q18.** Who was the first Bhikkuni? **Ans:** Mahaprajapati Gautami.
- Q19.** What was the name of Buddha's horse at his Great Departure? **Ans:** Kanthaka.
- Q20.** What is the standard PYQ definition of Nirvana? **Ans:** "The extinction of the flame of desire."
- Q21.** What are the Triratna of Buddhism? **Ans:** Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha.
- Q22.** Who patronised the Third Buddhist Council at Pataliputra? **Ans:** Ashoka.
- Q23.** Which council caused the Hinayana-Mahayana split, and who patronised it? **Ans:** Fourth Council, Kundalvan (Kashmir); patronised by Kanishka.
- Q24.** Which Buddhist sect believes in idol worship and the concept of Bodhisattva? **Ans:** Mahayana.
- Q25.** What was the main cause of the decline of Buddhism? **Ans:** Lack of sustained royal patronage.
- Q26.** Which is the largest stupa in India? **Ans:** Kesariya, Bihar.
- Q27.** Which stupa depicts the Jataka Tales? **Ans:** Bharhut, Madhya Pradesh.

20. Last-Minute One-Page Revision

THE ENTIRE PART IN ONE FLOW

BRAHMIN DOMINATION + TRADE ECONOMY → HETERODOX REACTION (Kshatriya-led) → JAINISM (Rishabhadeva founds; Mahavira systematises; Panchvrata; Digambara vs Shvetambara; 2 councils; 12 Angas) → BUDDHISM (Buddha's life; Four Noble Truths; Eightfold Path; Tripitaka; 4 councils → Hinayana/Mahayana split) → ARCHITECTURE (Stupas, Chaityas, Viharas, universities) → DECLINE (loss of royal patronage) → feeds into the Mahajanapada-era political history already covered in Part 4.